afraid that a rival—perhaps Bennett—would pull the same stunt against him.

He originally drew up a plan to move the settlers to an adjacent hilltop at state expense. But it was complicated when Yesh Din, an Israeli NGO, filed an appeal, claiming that the new site for Amona was also privately-owned. “The plots that the state is trying to declare as ‘abandoned properties’ are private lands with recognised owners,” said Gilad Grossman, a spokesman for the group. After two years of delay, the government didn’t have time to fight the injunction before the Christmas deadline. It hastily drew up another proposal, which moved about a dozen Amona families to a tiny plot of state land on their hilltop, and the rest to the nearby settlement of Ofra. On 15 December, the residents voted overwhelmingly (59–20) to reject it. They called it “Swiss cheese”, because it wouldn’t accommodate all of the outpost’s families, and it didn’t guarantee permanent homes on their new land.

Two days later, after Shabbat, Netanyahu convened a late-night meeting to discuss another compromise. The meeting ran until the small hours of the morning. Again, stop to consider the imagery: the Israeli prime minister sitting at 3 am with the emissaries of a group of scofflaws whose supporters were threatening violence against the state. While the cabinet was talking, a group of soldiers from the Givati Brigade ordered to secure the roads around Amona briefly abandoned their posts. They told their commanders that they would not take part in the evacuation, and only returned to duty after they were assured they would have no direct role. “The IDF condemns any kind of refusal to obey orders and will show zero tolerance towards it,” the army spokesman said in a brief statement—but the soldiers were not punished for their protest.

Finally, with less than a week before the deadline, the residents accepted the offer. The final agreement, which also included a state commitment to build a new settlement in the northern West Bank, allowed two-thirds of the families to stay on a plot of land near Amona (the rest would go to Ofra). It would cost 130 million shekels.

The “regularization bill”, as it is known in Hebrew, will almost certainly be overturned by the courts: even before it passed, the attorney general said he would struggle to defend it. The seemingly inevitable verdict will cement the high court’s reputation as a leftist body. (Miriam Naor, the chief justice, had her security detail increased at the height of the Amona debate.)